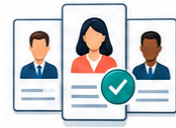


ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Human Resources English



Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

04 Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

05 Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

06 Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

07 Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

08 Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

job requirement - A capability, qualification, or responsibility needed for a role.

structured interview - An interview using planned job-related questions and consistent evaluation criteria.

bias - A systematic tendency that can distort judgment, measurement, selection, or results.

candidate experience - An applicant's experience of an organization's hiring process.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Translate cultural fit into job-related behavior

Fictional recruiting meeting: a hiring manager asks for good cultural fit, but the role requirements do not specify the relevant behaviors.

01 • Recruiter: When you say good cultural fit, which job-related behaviors do you want us to assess?

02 • Hiring manager: The current requirements don't spell that out. I was using fit as shorthand.

03 • Recruiter: Could we identify observable requirements rather than rely on whether a candidate feels familiar?

04 • Hiring manager: Yes. What would make the structured interview more consistent without inventing new duties?

05 • Recruiter: Start with the actual work requirements, then agree questions and evidence that relate to them.

06 • Hiring manager: So personal similarity shouldn't quietly become a selection criterion or a substitute for performance evidence?

07 • Recruiter: Correct. Ambiguous fit language can introduce bias and make the candidate experience difficult to explain.

08 • Hiring manager: I'll clarify the real responsibilities before we finalize the interview questions.

09 • Recruiter: Please also distinguish essential requirements from preferences so candidates receive an accurate description.

10 • Hiring manager: Agreed. We will define the behaviors and assessment basis before judging applicants against an undefined idea of fit.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A software preference mistaken for a requirement

Separate fictional hiring case: a role requires spreadsheet analysis, but a screening draft requires five years with one named spreadsheet product; no product-specific need is established.

01 • Talent partner: The role requires spreadsheet analysis. Why does the screening draft require five years with this particular product?

02 • Hiring manager: That duration and product choice haven't been justified against the actual job tasks.

03 • Talent partner: Could we clarify the analytical work before excluding applicants with equivalent experience in another tool?

04 • Hiring manager: Yes. We need evidence of the required skill, not an arbitrary proxy for it.

05 • Talent partner: Would a structured interview question about a relevant analysis task help assess that requirement?

06 • Hiring manager: Potentially, once the task and evaluation criteria are agreed and used consistently.

07 • Talent partner: I'll ask which outputs the role must produce and what level of independence is necessary.

08 • Hiring manager: I'll provide the actual task expectations and identify any genuinely necessary product constraint.

09 • Talent partner: Until then, I'll flag the unsupported restriction rather than treat it as an established essential requirement.

10 • Hiring manager: Good. That keeps the screening decision tied to work evidence and gives candidates a clearer explanation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Clarify a request for executive presence

Separate fictional interview debrief: one interviewer says a candidate lacks executive presence but provides no behavioral example or role-related criterion.

01 • Recruiting lead: You said the candidate lacked executive presence. Which observed response and job requirement are you referring to?

02 • Interview panel chair: I haven't connected that phrase to a specific criterion, so it needs clarification.

03 • Recruiting lead: Could accent, speaking style, or familiarity be influencing the impression rather than evidence of the required work?

04 • Interview panel chair: That's possible, but we shouldn't assume the cause of the rating either. Let's examine the actual notes.

05 • Recruiting lead: Please identify the response, the agreed criterion, and the evidence supporting the rating.

06 • Interview panel chair: I'll ask the interviewer to do that before the panel treats the phrase as a finding.

07 • Recruiting lead: If the evidence isn't available, can we record that limitation instead of inventing a behavioral example?

08 • Interview panel chair: Yes. We'll use the structured interview basis and leave unsupported judgments out of the decision rationale.

09 • Recruiting lead: That also helps us give accurate, job-related candidate communication.

10 • Interview panel chair: Agreed. We'll clarify the evidence first rather than turn an undefined impression into a selection rule.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Scenario 2 | Flexible hours without a defined schedule

A fictional job advertisement says flexible hours, but the hiring manager expects attendance at a fixed weekly meeting. The meeting time and other schedule requirements are unconfirmed. Clarify the actual job requirement before candidates are screened.

Role A: Recruiter: ask what flexibility and required attendance mean for this role.

Role B: Hiring manager: distinguish confirmed expectations from details still needing agreement.

Possible opening: When we say flexible hours, what attendance requirement do candidates actually need to meet?

Success checks

- Clarify the job-related schedule rather than personal circumstances.
- Do not invent the meeting time or availability requirement.
- Agree consistent wording and evidence for candidate discussions.

Add a complication: An interviewer wants to reject applicants based on assumptions about their family responsibilities.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Onboarding and Role Clarity

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

role clarity - A shared understanding of a person's responsibilities and authority.

onboarding - The process of helping a new employee or customer begin effectively.

manager check-in - A short discussion between a manager and employee about progress, needs, or expectations.

success measure - An agreed indicator used to judge whether an objective has been achieved.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Compare this wording: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
 - B. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - C. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?
 - B. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - C. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Accounts ready, first-month priorities missing

Fictional onboarding meeting: a new starter has equipment and accounts but no first-month priorities; the manager assumed the checklist covered expectations.

01 • HR coordinator: The equipment and accounts are ready, but the new starter still needs first-month priorities from you.

02 • Line manager: I thought completing the onboarding checklist gave them enough direction to begin the role.

03 • HR coordinator: It covers setup, not the work expectations. Please agree the initial priorities and success measures with them.

04 • Line manager: What timing would make that request useful without pretending we have every longer-term goal settled?

05 • HR coordinator: Could you arrange a manager check-in this week and confirm the time with the new starter?

06 • Line manager: Yes. I'll arrange the check-in and focus on the first month rather than invent a full-year plan.

07 • HR coordinator: Please distinguish the tasks they own from the decisions that still need your approval.

08 • Line manager: I'll include that role clarity and ask which support or information they still need.

09 • HR coordinator: Thank you. Please confirm the agreed priorities afterward so onboarding completion doesn't hide the missing expectations.

10 • Line manager: I will. The setup is complete, and I accept responsibility for clarifying the work plan.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A starter receives competing first-week requests

Separate fictional onboarding case: a new analyst receives a data-cleanup request from the manager and a same-week presentation request from another team; priority is unagreed.

01 • New analyst: I have data cleanup from you and a presentation request from the other team. Please clarify which takes priority.

02 • Line manager: Thank you for raising it. We haven't agreed the order, so neither request should become an assumed commitment.

03 • New analyst: Could we review the two requests today and confirm what success looks like for my first week?

04 • Line manager: Yes. Let's compare the actual deadlines and scope before assigning a priority.

05 • New analyst: Those details aren't fully confirmed, so I can't promise both will be complete this week.

06 • Line manager: Understood. I'll coordinate with the other team rather than ask you to resolve competing management expectations alone.

07 • New analyst: Please also confirm who approves the presentation if that becomes part of my initial work.

08 • Line manager: I'll clarify the approval owner during the coordination discussion and return a clear task order.

09 • New analyst: That will help me use the next manager check-in to report against agreed expectations.

10 • Line manager: Agreed. I'll confirm the priority and success measure before treating either request as a settled first-week deadline.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A buddy is not the performance decision maker

Separate fictional onboarding exercise: a buddy can explain team routines, but responsibility for setting the starter's objectives remains with the line manager.

01 • Onboarding buddy: I can explain team routines, but I need you to confirm the starter's objectives as their manager.

02 • Line manager: Could you set those objectives informally during your daily conversations to save us a meeting?

03 • Onboarding buddy: That would blur our roles. Please hold a check-in to agree priorities and success measures directly.

04 • Line manager: What information can you bring that would make the check-in more useful?

05 • Onboarding buddy: I can summarize the starter's questions about routines, without judging performance or making commitments on your behalf.

06 • Line manager: Please send the questions today; I'll confirm a meeting time with the starter tomorrow.

07 • Onboarding buddy: Thank you. Could you also explain where they should take conflicting task requests?

08 • Line manager: Yes. I'll clarify the escalation route and which decisions remain mine.

09 • Onboarding buddy: Then I can support onboarding without becoming an unannounced substitute for the manager.

10 • Line manager: Agreed. I own the objectives, and your support role will be clear to both the starter and the team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Onboarding and Role Clarity

A new starter has accounts and equipment but no first-month priorities. Their manager assumes the onboarding checklist covers expectations.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Scenario 2 | Access granted, training owner missing

A fictional new starter can open the case-management system, but no trainer or first supervised task is assigned. The starter is not being assessed yet. Request a bounded training arrangement before treating access as readiness.

Role A: New starter: ask for a trainer, initial task, and check-in arrangement.

Role B: Line manager: accept coordination responsibility and confirm when an arrangement can be proposed.

Possible opening: My access works; could you arrange the initial training and identify who will supervise my first task?

Success checks

- Separate access from demonstrated readiness.
- Request a clear training owner and first-task scope.
- Agree a realistic confirmation point without inventing completed training.

Add a complication: A colleague says account access proves the starter can work independently.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Performance Feedback and Documentation

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step.

SITUATION

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

performance gap - The difference between expected and observed performance.

documentation - Written evidence of what was done, why, by whom, when, and under which authority.

expectation - A stated or assumed understanding of what should happen or be delivered.

support plan - Agreed actions and resources intended to help a person or team meet an identified need.

3. Notice the language

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

In [specific situation], I noticed ...

The effect was ... What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Compare this wording: You are always careless.

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give feedback people can use

4. Check the language

1. Which feedback begins with observable behavior?
 - A. The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.
 - B. The last two updates seemed less professional than usual.
 - C. I think the team needs to be more committed to the updates.
2. Which follow-up invites useful information before agreeing on support?
 - A. Can you promise this will never happen again?
 - B. Would another reminder solve this problem?
 - C. What is making this part of the task difficult?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two reports missing the agreed summary

Fictional feedback conversation: the employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section; the reason is unknown.

01 • Line manager: Your last two reports omitted the summary section we agreed to include.

02 • Reporting analyst: I understand that's a performance gap. Can we clarify its effect before discussing the next step?

03 • Line manager: Readers didn't receive the agreed overview in those reports. I want to understand what prevented its inclusion.

04 • Reporting analyst: The reason isn't established by the missing sections alone, so thank you for asking rather than assuming motivation.

05 • Line manager: Would reviewing the expected structure together help identify what support or clarification is needed?

06 • Reporting analyst: Yes. Please confirm what the summary should contain so I can work against a clear expectation.

07 • Line manager: We'll use the agreed requirements and check the next report for that section before submission.

08 • Reporting analyst: That gives us a specific follow-up rather than a general instruction to try harder.

09 • Line manager: I'll document the observed omissions and the agreed support plan, without making a character judgment.

10 • Reporting analyst: Agreed. I'll raise any remaining uncertainty about the summary before the next report is due.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A handover omits the unresolved question

Separate fictional feedback case: an analyst's two latest handovers omitted the open customer question, requiring the receiving team to ask for it again.

01 • Team manager: The last two handovers omitted the open customer question, so the receiving team had to request it again.

02 • Operations analyst: Are you saying the entire handover was poor, or focusing on that missing element?

03 • Team manager: I'm focusing on the missing question and the additional clarification it caused, not rating everything you did.

04 • Operations analyst: That distinction helps. What specific expectation should we use for the next handover?

05 • Team manager: State the unresolved question and its current owner so the receiver knows what still needs attention.

06 • Operations analyst: Could we review one example together before I prepare the next case transfer?

07 • Team manager: Yes. We'll use an actual case and check the wording without inventing a completed answer.

08 • Operations analyst: I'll include the open question and ask the receiver to confirm the handover is clear.

09 • Team manager: Good. We'll review that observable change, not make assumptions about how much you care about the work.

10 • Operations analyst: Agreed. Please record that specific expectation and support step so I know what we will assess.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Feedback about an interrupted presentation

Separate fictional manager-coaching case: a supervisor interrupted a colleague three times before the colleague finished explaining a staffing concern.

01 • HR business partner: During the discussion, you interrupted three times before the colleague finished explaining the staffing concern.

02 • Supervisor: I was trying to keep the meeting short. Are you saying I never listen to anyone?

03 • HR business partner: No. I'm describing this interaction and its effect: the concern wasn't fully heard before you responded.

04 • Supervisor: What would be a useful change at the next meeting rather than a vague instruction to be nicer?

05 • HR business partner: Let the speaker finish the concern, summarize your understanding, then ask the focused question you need.

06 • Supervisor: Could you observe the next discussion and give feedback on those specific behaviors?

07 • HR business partner: Yes. We'll agree the observation scope and discuss examples afterward, without assuming intentions.

08 • Supervisor: I'll explain the meeting time limit at the start instead of interrupting the explanation repeatedly.

09 • HR business partner: That is a practical approach. Keep the performance expectation tied to behavior the speaker can experience.

10 • Supervisor: Agreed. I'll try it and review the result with you rather than claim the communication problem is already solved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Performance Feedback and Documentation

An employee's last two reports omitted the agreed summary section. The manager wants to discuss the issue without making a judgment about motivation.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Scenario 2 | A status label changed without an explanation

A fictional coordinator changed two project statuses from pending to delayed without explaining the reason, causing the receiving team to ask for clarification. The cause of the omission is unknown. Practice behavior-focused feedback and a bounded support step.

Role A: Line manager: describe the two changes and their effect.

Role B: Project coordinator: ask for a clear expectation and agree how to check the next update.

Possible opening: The two status changes had no reason attached, so the receiving team needed a separate clarification.

Success checks

- Use the observed omission and effect.
- Avoid assigning motivation or a character label.
- Agree a specific explanation requirement and follow-up check.

Add a complication: The manager initially calls the coordinator careless rather than describing the missing information.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Employee Relations and Investigations

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

employee relations - Managing workplace relationships, concerns, disputes, and related organizational processes.

harassment - Unwelcome conduct assessed under applicable workplace rules and law; specific legal definitions vary.

retaliation - Adverse treatment in response to protected reporting or activity, as defined by applicable rules.

confidentiality - Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Compare this wording: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

One employee account is not an investigation finding

Fictional employee-relations intake: a concern about a colleague has been reported, but the manager has only one account and no findings.

01 • Receiving manager: An employee raised a concern about a colleague. I have only that person's account so far.

02 • Employee relations adviser: Then the intake should distinguish what was reported from any finding about what occurred.

03 • Receiving manager: Can I call it confirmed harassment to show that I take the concern seriously?

04 • Employee relations adviser: Taking it seriously doesn't require an unestablished conclusion. Preserve the account and use the appropriate review process.

05 • Receiving manager: Should I promise absolute confidentiality before the employee shares any further details?

06 • Employee relations adviser: Don't promise more than the process permits. Explain the appropriate handling and any limits through the relevant guidance.

07 • Receiving manager: I'll avoid attributing motives and ask for concrete events rather than suggest an answer.

08 • Employee relations adviser: Good. Also communicate any reported retaliation concern through the proper route without assuming a finding.

09 • Receiving manager: I'll record the source of the account and keep the assessment status explicitly open.

10 • Employee relations adviser: I'll help route the intake for qualified review, with no promise about the eventual conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A changed shift after a complaint needs examination

Separate fictional intake case: an employee reports that their shift changed after they raised a concern; the reason for the change and the decision maker's knowledge are unknown.

01 • HR intake specialist: The employee reports a shift change after raising a concern. The reason for that change is unknown.

02 • Department manager: Does the timing prove retaliation, or can we dismiss it as an ordinary scheduling change?

03 • HR intake specialist: Neither conclusion is established. The sequence is relevant information to preserve and review.

04 • Department manager: What can I accurately say to the employee about how their concern is being treated?

05 • HR intake specialist: Acknowledge the reported sequence and explain that it will be assessed through the appropriate employee-relations process.

06 • Department manager: Should I ask them whether the scheduling manager intended to punish them?

07 • HR intake specialist: Ask for concrete events and sources, not speculation about another person's unverified intention.

08 • Department manager: I'll preserve the schedule records and avoid announcing a finding to the wider team.

09 • HR intake specialist: Good. Respect the applicable confidentiality arrangements without promising that nobody else will need information.

10 • Department manager: I'll keep the report, known sequence, and unresolved questions separate in the handoff to the reviewer.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A forwarded message without its surrounding exchange

Separate fictional employee-relations case: a manager receives one forwarded workplace message; the surrounding conversation and sender's explanation are unavailable.

01 • Line manager: This forwarded message sounds hostile. Can I describe the sender as threatening in the intake summary?

02 • Employee relations consultant: Preserve the actual wording and your source, but don't replace the limited evidence with a broader characterization.

03 • Line manager: We don't have the surrounding exchange. Does that mean the concern should be ignored until we do?

04 • Employee relations consultant: No. Route the concern appropriately while identifying the missing context; incompleteness doesn't make it irrelevant.

05 • Line manager: Could I paraphrase the message more strongly so the reviewer understands why it concerned me?

06 • Employee relations consultant: Use accurate wording and separate your concern from what the message itself says.

07 • Line manager: I'll keep the original forwarded material and request review through the confidential intake route.

08 • Employee relations consultant: Please don't circulate it widely to seek opinions about the sender's character.

09 • Line manager: I'll identify the missing context and avoid assuming the sender's intent or the eventual finding.

10 • Employee relations consultant: Good. A careful intake can take the concern seriously while leaving assessment to the authorized process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Employee Relations and Investigations

An employee raises a concern about a colleague. The receiving manager has only one account and is preparing an intake note.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Scenario 2 | A secondhand concern in a team meeting

A fictional manager heard from a colleague that another employee felt excluded from a project meeting. The manager has not spoken with that employee and has no meeting records yet. Practice an intake handoff that identifies the secondhand source.

Role A: Receiving manager: describe what you heard and from whom without inventing the employee's words.

Role B: Employee-relations adviser: ask which facts are direct observations and arrange appropriate follow-up.

Possible opening: This is a secondhand report; I haven't yet heard the employee's own account.

Success checks

- Attribute the report accurately.
- Separate possible exclusion from a finding about intent.
- Agree the appropriate follow-up while respecting information-sharing limits.

Add a complication: A colleague asks you to label the exclusion deliberate before the meeting records are reviewed.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

pay band - An organization's defined pay range for a role or group of roles.

job level - A position's place in an organization's framework of responsibility and complexity.

equity review - An examination of differences in pay, access, or outcomes for fairness under defined criteria.

benefits - Non-wage parts of an employment package, such as leave or insurance arrangements.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Compare this wording: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - C. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

The pay-band midpoint is not everyone's salary

Fictional compensation explanation: a published pay range is available, an employee assumes everyone receives the midpoint, and the HR team has the applicable policy.

01 • People manager: The employee thinks everyone in the role receives the midpoint of the published pay band.

02 • Compensation adviser: A range describes boundaries; its midpoint isn't automatically the salary of every person in that role.

03 • People manager: Can I explain what determines their individual salary without checking the applicable compensation policy?

04 • Compensation adviser: We should use that policy and the relevant job-level information rather than invent a formula.

05 • People manager: So I can clarify the range distinction now while the individual explanation is being checked?

06 • Compensation adviser: Yes. Be clear that the published midpoint alone doesn't establish an entitlement or a promised adjustment.

07 • People manager: Would an equity review mean a salary change has already been approved?

08 • Compensation adviser: No. Review and an authorized compensation decision are different stages.

09 • People manager: I'll explain those distinctions and ask you to verify the policy basis for the individual discussion.

10 • Compensation adviser: I'll review the relevant information through the appropriate process and avoid sharing another employee's private compensation details.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Base salary and the benefits package are different figures

Separate fictional offer discussion: a candidate asks whether the stated base salary includes the employer's benefits contribution; the offer details have not been reconciled with the benefits summary.

01 • Recruiter: The candidate asks whether the base salary figure includes the employer benefits contribution. How should I explain the distinction?

02 • Benefits specialist: Base salary and benefits are different components; the actual offer documents should specify how each is presented.

03 • Recruiter: Could I add a guessed benefits value to make the offer sound more competitive?

04 • Benefits specialist: No. Use verified figures and conditions rather than turn an unconfirmed estimate into a compensation promise.

05 • Recruiter: The offer and benefits summary haven't been reconciled, so I should identify that check as pending.

06 • Benefits specialist: Correct. We can explain the categories without pretending the individual package calculation is complete.

07 • Recruiter: I'll say the salary figure needs to be read alongside the separate benefits information.

08 • Benefits specialist: Please also avoid implying every benefit is cash paid directly to the employee.

09 • Recruiter: I'll request the verified package explanation before giving a total-compensation figure to the candidate.

10 • Benefits specialist: I'll confirm the relevant terms and keep eligibility or enrollment conditions tied to the actual documents.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Same job title does not establish the same job level

Separate fictional compensation case: two internal positions share a title, but their job levels and responsibilities have not been compared.

01 • Department manager: These positions have the same title. Can I assume they belong in the same pay band?

02 • Job evaluation specialist: Not from the title alone. We need the actual responsibilities and job-level assessment.

03 • Department manager: Would a different pay band prove that someone has been treated unfairly in this case?

04 • Job evaluation specialist: That conclusion isn't established either. The underlying role information and relevant review need to be examined.

05 • Department manager: How can I explain the distinction without dismissing an employee's concern about equity?

06 • Job evaluation specialist: Acknowledge the concern, then explain that titles and evaluated job levels are different pieces of information.

07 • Department manager: I'll request an appropriate equity review rather than announce the result before the comparison.

08 • Job evaluation specialist: Good. Keep the discussion focused on the employee's role and the applicable process.

09 • Department manager: I won't use another employee's private salary as an informal explanation of the band.

10 • Job evaluation specialist: I'll help verify the role comparison and communicate the reviewed basis without promising a particular pay outcome.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

An employee sees a published pay range and assumes everyone in the role receives the midpoint. The HR team has the relevant compensation policy.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Scenario 2 | A percentage increase confused with a new band

A fictional compensation notice mentions a proposed salary increase but does not state any change in job level. The employee assumes promotion is confirmed. Discuss the difference while the proposal remains under review.

Role A: People manager: distinguish a salary proposal from a confirmed level change.

Role B: Compensation adviser: identify what the actual notice supports and what needs verification.

Possible opening: The notice proposes a salary change; it does not confirm a promotion or new job level.

Success checks

- Keep salary, job level, and approval status distinct.
- Do not promise either outcome from the proposal alone.
- Agree a document-based clarification through the appropriate review process.

Add a complication: The manager wants to announce a promotion to improve morale before approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Policy Communication and Compliance

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

policy - Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

accommodation - An adjustment intended to address a person's access or participation needs.

precedent - An earlier decision or example relevant to a later one; legal authority depends on context.

compliance - Conformance with laws, regulations, standards, policies, contracts, or approved procedures.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Compare this wording: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when the review starts?
 - B. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - C. Could you confirm when starts the review?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?
 - B. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - C. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A work-adjustment request is not automatic approval

Fictional HR clarification: a manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved; the applicable process review has not occurred.

01 • Line manager: The employee requested a work adjustment. Does submitting the request mean it is automatically approved?

02 • HR adviser: No approval is established here. Could you clarify what was requested and which process has been initiated?

03 • Line manager: The review hasn't happened, and I shouldn't decide the outcome from the request alone.

04 • HR adviser: Correct. We need the relevant facts and applicable policy process, with sensitive information handled appropriately.

05 • Line manager: Could I use a previous colleague's arrangement as proof that the same result must apply?

06 • HR adviser: A previous case doesn't settle this one. Don't turn a precedent into an automatic decision without review.

07 • Line manager: I'll describe the status as received and awaiting the appropriate assessment, not approved or rejected.

08 • HR adviser: Please also clarify the employee's question without requesting unnecessary personal details in team communications.

09 • Line manager: I'll route the request through the designated channel and ask who will confirm the next step.

10 • HR adviser: I'll identify the reviewer and explain the process without promising a particular accommodation or legal conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A policy date and a publication date differ

Separate fictional policy exercise: an internal notice was posted on Monday but says the policy takes effect the following month; a manager assumes it applies immediately.

01 • Department supervisor: The notice appeared Monday. Should I apply the new policy to this week's requests?

02 • People operations specialist: Could you check the effective date? The notice says the following month, not the posting date.

03 • Department supervisor: So publication and the date the policy begins are separate, even though both appear on the notice?

04 • People operations specialist: Yes. We also need any applicable transition instructions rather than assume how current requests are handled.

05 • Department supervisor: Those instructions aren't supplied here. Can I make an exception and call it a precedent?

06 • People operations specialist: Don't invent an exception or broader rule. Ask the responsible policy owner for clarification.

07 • Department supervisor: I'll confirm which version governs the current request before giving the employee an answer.

08 • People operations specialist: Please include the notice reference and the timing question so the request is focused.

09 • Department supervisor: I'll keep the outcome open rather than treat publication as immediate approval or rejection.

10 • People operations specialist: Good. We'll return the verified policy interpretation through the appropriate process for this specific case.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An informal yes with no confirmed authority

Separate fictional HR case: a team lead informally said yes to a schedule request, but their authority and the applicable approval process are unconfirmed.

01 • HR coordinator: The team lead said yes to the schedule request. Do we know whether they had approval authority?

02 • Department manager: That hasn't been confirmed. We need to clarify the policy process before describing the arrangement as final.

03 • HR coordinator: Should I tell the employee the request is rejected because the informal response may be insufficient?

04 • Department manager: No. Unconfirmed approval isn't the same as rejection; we need the actual decision status.

05 • HR coordinator: I'll ask who can authorize this request and whether any required review has taken place.

06 • Department manager: Please also preserve the earlier communication so we can explain the uncertainty without blaming the employee.

07 • HR coordinator: Could another team's similar arrangement settle the authority question for this request?

08 • Department manager: Not by itself. The applicable process and scope need verification rather than an assumption based on precedent.

09 • HR coordinator: I'll describe the informal response accurately and request confirmation through the designated route.

10 • Department manager: I'll support that clarification and avoid making a policy or accommodation commitment before the responsible review.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Policy Communication and Compliance

A manager asks whether a requested work adjustment is automatically approved. HR has not yet reviewed the request under the applicable process.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Scenario 2 | A policy answer from an unverified handbook version

A fictional manager uses a saved handbook to answer an employee's request, but the current handbook version has not been checked. No approval or rejection has been communicated. Clarify which version applies before responding.

Role A: HR coordinator: request the version reference and applicable-date check.

Role B: Line manager: acknowledge the uncertainty and agree to use the verified policy source.

Possible opening: Before we answer, could we confirm that this saved handbook is the version that applies to the request?

Success checks

- Distinguish familiar wording from an applicable policy.
- Do not invent a legal rule or request outcome.
- Agree the source check and responsible clarification route.

Add a complication: A coworker says the old wording must still apply because it is easier to understand.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

SITUATION

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

mediation - A process in which a neutral third party helps participants work toward resolving a disagreement.

behavioral example - A specific description of what a person did or said.

operating agreement - An agreed description of how people will coordinate work and responsibilities.

accountability - Responsibility for explaining decisions and following through on agreed work.

3. Notice the language

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Compare this wording: Nobody objected, so everyone agrees.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Help a group reach a clear next step

4. Check the language

1. Which phrase invites a missing perspective?
 - A. The remote team has been quiet, so they must agree.
 - B. We can record their agreement without asking them.
 - C. We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?
2. Which closing statement records an unresolved decision accurately?
 - A. Everyone spoke, so the decision must be final.
 - B. Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.
 - C. We discussed the options, so approval is complete.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A recurring task with undocumented ownership

Fictional facilitated meeting about Friday's dashboard: ownership is undocumented, and any earlier verbal agreement is unconfirmed. Analyst Nora receives raw data Thursday at 16:00; coordinator Owen receives returns figures Friday at 10:00. Team manager Priya can assign responsibilities.

01 • Team manager Priya: Nora, please explain your understanding of dashboard ownership and the information you receive.

02 • Analyst Nora: I thought Owen owned publication. I receive raw data Thursday at four and can prepare that section.

03 • Team manager Priya: Owen, what is your understanding, and what affects your part of the work?

04 • Coordinator Owen: I expected Nora to publish everything, but my returns figures arrive Friday at ten.

05 • Team manager Priya: Let's separate preparation from publication. Nora, can you prepare the data section, with Owen owning publication?

06 • Analyst Nora: Yes, provided I'm not accountable for returns figures before Owen receives them.

07 • Team manager Priya: Owen, can you add the returns figures and flag any delay rather than assume they're complete?

08 • Coordinator Owen: Yes. I'll own publication and raise missing returns data with you before publishing.

09 • Team manager Priya: That's our future operating agreement. I own escalation decisions; any earlier verbal agreement remains unconfirmed.

10 • Analyst Nora: Understood: I prepare my section, Owen adds returns and publishes, and unresolved data comes to you.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Who books the meeting and who prepares the agenda?

Separate fictional facilitated meeting: room booking is due Wednesday at noon and the agenda Thursday at 16:00. Room coordinator Eli needs a confirmed headcount; agenda coordinator Sana has topics but lacks presenter confirmations. Project manager Jo can assign responsibilities. Headcount and room availability remain unknown.

01 • Project manager Jo: Eli, what is preventing the room booking, and which input do you need?

02 • Room coordinator Eli: I need a confirmed headcount before Wednesday noon. I assumed Sana would supply it.

03 • Project manager Jo: Sana, please explain your agenda work and whether that headcount responsibility was clear.

04 • Agenda coordinator Sana: I have the topics but still need presenter confirmations. I hadn't understood that I owned headcount.

05 • Project manager Jo: I'll assign room booking to Eli and agenda preparation to Sana. Eli, can you reserve provisionally?

06 • Room coordinator Eli: I can't promise that; room availability and provisional booking conditions haven't been checked.

07 • Project manager Jo: Then Sana, can you verify attendance by Wednesday ten and flag unanswered invitations to me?

08 • Agenda coordinator Sana: Yes. I'll own that check and separately pursue presenter confirmations for Thursday's agenda.

09 • Project manager Jo: Agreed. I decide unresolved attendance questions; room availability remains open, not guaranteed by this agreement.

10 • Room coordinator Eli: I'll check availability using the verified headcount and escalate any obstacle to the noon booking deadline.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Two deadlines competing for one employee's time

Separate fictional facilitated discussion: sales needs a customer briefing Friday at noon; operations prefers its internal summary Friday but can accept Monday. Analyst Ren estimates four hours for each and has five working hours available before the customer deadline. Ren also has four working hours available Monday. Department head Mira decides priorities.

01 • Department head Mira: Let's hear both deadlines before assigning Ren's time. Sales, what makes your timing necessary?

02 • Sales lead: The customer briefing is confirmed for Friday noon. We need Ren's analysis for that meeting.

03 • Department head Mira: Operations, is Friday an external commitment or a preferred date for your summary?

04 • Operations lead: It's our preferred internal date. Monday would work, provided the revised timing is clear.

05 • Department head Mira: Ren, what capacity and task estimates should we consider before deciding the order?

06 • Analyst Ren: Each task needs about four hours. I have five hours before the customer deadline, plus four on Monday.

07 • Department head Mira: I own the priority decision: customer analysis first, internal summary Monday. Operations, can you accept that change?

08 • Operations lead: Yes. I'll tell the receiving team Monday is the revised expectation, rather than call Friday a missed commitment.

09 • Department head Mira: Ren, please confirm the order and bring any changed estimate to me for another decision.

10 • Analyst Ren: Customer analysis first, internal summary Monday. I'll raise capacity changes instead of silently promising both for Friday.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Two colleagues disagree about who owns a recurring task. Both say the other failed to help, but the responsibilities were never documented.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You hold a relevant concern that has not been discussed. Raise it when invited and ask who will decide. Help the facilitator state one unresolved question accurately.

Second round: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Model for scenario 1: Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Scenario 2 | A handoff deadline means different things

Two fictional colleagues agree on a Thursday handoff, but one means Thursday morning and the other means end of day. No time was previously agreed. Facilitate a specific future arrangement without blaming either interpretation as a broken promise.

Role A: HR mediator: summarize the ambiguity and invite both scheduling needs.

Role B: Team manager: clarify decision authority and agree a precise future handoff arrangement with the participants.

Possible opening: Thursday was agreed, but a time was not, so let's clarify the next handoff rather than assume a broken agreement.

Success checks

- Separate an ambiguous agreement from proven misconduct.
- Hear the relevant timing needs before assigning a deadline.
- Confirm an owner, specific timing, and an escalation route for future difficulty.

Add a complication: One colleague asks you to record that the other deliberately missed the deadline.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

SITUATION

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

restructuring - A significant change to an organization's roles, reporting lines, or operations.

position elimination - The removal of a job role from an organization's structure.

severance - Pay or benefits associated with employment termination under the relevant agreement or rules.

talking points - Prepared key messages intended to guide a conversation or presentation.

3. Notice the language

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Compare this wording: I'm sorry if you failed to understand.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Repair a misunderstanding

4. Check the language

1. Which apology takes responsibility for unclear wording?
 - A. I'm sorry we could not meet the original date.
 - B. I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.
 - C. I'm sorry the process took longer than expected.
2. What should follow an apology for an incorrect date?
 - A. The corrected date and the current confirmation status.
 - B. A longer explanation that never states the correct date.
 - C. A new guaranteed date even if it is unverified.

05 • Conversations

The next three pages contain original fictional conversations for this lesson. Each numbered line is one speaking turn. Read the setting before assigning roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Small changes understates possible position impacts

Fictional restructuring-message review: a draft says small changes although some positions may be affected; final details remain unconfirmed.

01 • Communications manager: Our draft says small changes, but some positions may be affected. That wording could minimize the uncertainty.

02 • HR director: Agreed. We need a clearer message without announcing decisions that haven't been confirmed.

03 • Communications manager: Would positions will be eliminated be a more honest replacement for the vague phrase?

04 • HR director: That goes too far in the other direction. Possible impact is not a confirmed position elimination.

05 • Communications manager: Then I'll say the restructuring may affect positions and final details are still being reviewed.

06 • HR director: Yes. Acknowledge that the earlier phrase did not communicate the possible impact clearly.

07 • Communications manager: Should the talking points include a promised severance arrangement to reassure employees?

08 • HR director: Only confirmed, applicable information through the proper process; no such arrangement is established here.

09 • Communications manager: I'll correct the wording and distinguish what is known from the questions that remain open.

10 • HR director: I'll coordinate the reviewed employee communication and identify the next information route without inventing dates or outcomes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Correcting a promise that no roles would change

Separate fictional restructuring case: a manager said no roles would change, but the approved planning status is that role impacts remain under review.

01 • People manager: I told the team no roles would change, but that assurance wasn't supported by the current planning status.

02 • HR partner: We should correct it directly. What can you say that reflects what is actually confirmed?

03 • People manager: I said no roles would change. That was too definite; role impacts are still under review.

04 • HR partner: Good. Acknowledge the uncertainty your correction may create rather than pretend the original message was harmless.

05 • People manager: Could I replace the assurance with a promise that any changes will be voluntary?

06 • HR partner: No. That condition isn't supplied or confirmed, so it would create another unsupported commitment.

07 • People manager: I'll use the reviewed talking points and direct questions to the agreed information channel.

08 • HR partner: Please distinguish unknown outcomes from information you are authorized to share but haven't yet communicated.

09 • People manager: I'll be explicit about what remains unconfirmed and avoid speculating about particular employees.

10 • HR partner: I'll review the correction with you so the team hears accountability and accurate status rather than a second reassurance we cannot support.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A planning chart mistaken for a final structure

Separate fictional employee conversation: team coordinator Alex saw an organization chart without a draft label. HR program manager Sam is correcting that communication. The chart is a planning draft; final restructuring decisions, individual impacts, and any severance arrangements are unconfirmed.

01 • HR program manager Sam: I'm sorry we shared the chart without a draft label. It is a planning draft; final restructuring decisions remain unconfirmed.

02 • Team coordinator Alex: It looked final to me. Does my position appearing on it guarantee that my role will continue?

03 • HR program manager Sam: No. The draft doesn't confirm individual outcomes. Our missing label created that misleading impression, not your reading of it.

04 • Team coordinator Alex: Then should I assume positions missing from the chart have already been eliminated?

05 • HR program manager Sam: No. That conclusion is also unconfirmed. The chart does not establish a final structure or position elimination.

06 • Team coordinator Alex: What about severance? Some colleagues think the chart means an arrangement has already been decided.

07 • HR program manager Sam: No arrangement is confirmed here. I'll take that question through the reviewed HR communication process rather than speculate.

08 • Team coordinator Alex: So the correction is that this was a draft, and neither role outcomes nor severance are confirmed?

09 • HR program manager Sam: Exactly. I accept responsibility for that correction and for routing the unanswered questions.

10 • Team coordinator Alex: Thank you. That clarifies the status without another guarantee.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

A restructuring message uses the phrase "small changes" even though some positions may be affected. The final details are not yet confirmed.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are frustrated because an earlier message created an expectation. Explain that expectation. Ask your partner to distinguish the correction from anything still uncertain.

Second round: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Model for scenario 1: The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Scenario 2 | A consultation described as an announcement

A fictional calendar invitation labels an upcoming restructuring consultation a final announcement. The meeting is intended to gather input, and no final position decisions exist. Practice a correction that makes the meeting's purpose clear.

Role A: People communications lead: acknowledge the misleading invitation and explain the consultation purpose.

Role B: Department manager: ask how to answer questions without promising a particular outcome.

Possible opening: The invitation called this a final announcement, but the meeting is a consultation to gather input.

Success checks

- Correct the invitation's decision-status implication.
- Distinguish an opportunity for input from a guaranteed outcome.
- Agree reviewed talking points and the appropriate route for unresolved questions.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to say consultation guarantees that nothing will change.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

Continue scenario 1 with an AI partner.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response to scenario 1, not a script to memorize. Assess your spoken version using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Onboarding and Role Clarity

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: B - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

B: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

C: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

Check 2: A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: The requested action and information are explicit.

B: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

C: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

Model response: Could we agree on three first-month priorities and a check-in date? The checklist covers setup; the new starter also needs to know what successful work looks like.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Performance Feedback and Documentation

Editing example: The last two reports omitted the agreed summary section.

The revision identifies observable work. 'Always' and a personality judgment make the feedback harder to verify or act on.

Check 1: A - The last two updates omitted the agreed completion date.

A: The recipient can check the specific examples and discuss how to improve them.

B: "Less professional" is an evaluation; it does not identify a specific observable omission.

C: Commitment is an interpretation, not a description of what the updates contained.

Check 2: C - What is making this part of the task difficult?

A: A promise does not reveal the obstacle or what support would help.

B: This proposes a solution before finding out what is making the task difficult.

C: An open question may reveal a barrier the speaker has not considered.

Model response: The last two reports did not include the summary section we agreed on. That made review slower. What would help you include it consistently, and can we check the next report together?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Employee Relations and Investigations

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: I'll record the concern in the employee's own terms and distinguish reported information from established findings. The appropriate process should determine the next steps; we should not prejudge the outcome.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Compensation, Benefits, and Equity

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

C: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

Model response: The range describes the span for the role, not a promise of the midpoint. Let's review the applicable policy and the factors the organization uses to explain an individual's position within the range.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Policy Communication and Compliance

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: A - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

B: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

C: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

Check 2: C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

B: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

C: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

Model response: Could you describe the requested adjustment and the work requirement involved? We'll review it through the appropriate process. I cannot confirm an outcome before that review.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Conflict Mediation and Manager Coaching

Editing example: Before I record agreement, does anyone have a concern or need more time?

The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Check 1: C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view?

A: Silence does not establish agreement.

B: Recording agreement without checking may misrepresent the team's view.

C: It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.

Check 2: B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options.

A: Participation alone does not establish a decision.

B: This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

C: Discussion does not itself constitute approval.

Model response: Let's identify the task, the handoff point, and what each person understood. Then we can agree on responsibilities and a check-in instead of continuing with assumptions about intent.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Restructuring and Sensitive Communication

Editing example: I'm sorry my message did not explain the timing clearly.

The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Check 1: B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear.

A: This acknowledges a missed date, not the communication problem in the question.

B: This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.

C: This acknowledges duration, but does not take responsibility for the unclear wording.

Check 2: A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status.

A: A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

B: The reader still lacks the information they need.

C: An unsupported new promise can create a second misunderstanding.

Model response: The wording may understate the possible impact. Let's say clearly what is confirmed, what remains undecided, and where employees can ask questions, using the approved communication process.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the following prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Vocabulary and grammar prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has four practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

Each starter prompt uses B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-30. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Human Resources English

Professional audience: HR business partners, recruiters, talent managers, people managers, employee-relations staff, learning teams, compensation analysts, and HR-adjacent leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Recruiting, Screening, and Candidate Experience

Original fictional case: A hiring manager asks for a candidate with "good cultural fit." The role requirements do not explain which behaviors matter.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: job requirement: A capability, qualification, or responsibility needed for a role. / structured interview: An interview using planned job-related questions and consistent evaluation criteria. / bias: A systematic tendency that can distort judgment, measurement, selection, or results. / candidate experience: An applicant's experience of an organization's hiring process.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Which job-related behaviors do you mean? Let's use clear requirements and consistent interview questions so candidates are assessed against the work the role actually involves.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level